

debut *Taare Zameen Par* and his production, *Jaane Tu...Ya Jaane Na*, is being courted by everyone. Bachchan took him aside at the power premiere of his *Jaane Tu...Ya Jaane Na* and declared he would like to be directed by him. Shah Rukh told him at the infamous party that they owed it to their fans to work together. And Salman invited him and his nephew Imran Khan to his TV show to help pro-

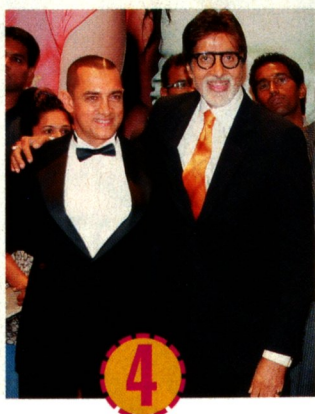
this combustible mix, the increasing role of corporate houses in making cinema and the tendency of politicians to appropriate stars for their own best interests. It gives them bragging rights in the right circles just as it gives stars the illusion of power.

Since this is still an industry where too much money is chasing too little talent, and with every studio in hot pursuit of the handful of jewels in the crown,

has been around even longer—his first blockbuster was in 1973. Even Akshay Kumar hit the ground running with *Khiladi* in 1992. That's stardom that has transcended enormous changes in society, from a one-television-nation to one with multiplexes, malls, mobiles and the Internet. That's stardom that also keeps the audience engaged through their many love affairs, career meltdowns and camp changes. And that's

BATTLE BEYOND THE BOX-OFFICE

- 1 **SHOW ME THE BUDDY** If Shah Rukh pals Karan Johar and Rani Mukerji appeared on *Kya Aap Paanchvi Pass Se Tez Hai*, Salman got Govinda and David Dhawan for *Dus Ka Dum*.
- 2 **GUEST RELATIONS** Star cameos such as in *OSO* are a major promotional hook for movies today. The bigger the star, the bigger the star cameos. If a favour is asked, it has to be returned.
- 3 **AWARD NO SHOW** Akshay Kumar at IIFA but not all stars turn up for all shows. It's often a function of who hosts and who promotes.
- 4 **POWER PARTIES** Guest lists indicate the position in the hierarchy. Everyone turned up for Aamir's nephew's debut film, as they did for Salman's bash for girlfriend Katrina Kaif.
- 5 **THE CAMP THAT TOURS TOGETHER...** Stays together? If Shah Rukh's *Temptation Reloaded* had his acolytes, the Bachchans are carrying their camp on their world tour.



mote their movie.

In this emerging Bollywood, the stakes are higher, with no big movie costing less than Rs 50 crore and with the ancillary industries mushrooming around the star—the actor is now not just the star of his film, but also of his own TV show, his endorsements, his concerts and awards show (which he often hosts himself). Thanks to Bachchan's blog writing abilities, he is also now his own best publicist. Add to

appearances matter. Sweetheart deals have to be backed by success at the box-office which is why competition is intense. With all the major stars on the wrong side of 40, there is a certain desperation to remain in the limelight. After all, Aamir hit the big time with *Qayamat Se Qayamat Tak* in 1988, Salman's first big hit, *Maine Pyaar Kiya* was in 1989, and Shah Rukh hit the headlines in 1992 with *Deewana* and *Raju Ban Gaya Gentleman*. Bachchan

stardom that's constantly looking over its shoulder at who the next big thing is.

It's an incestuous industry where everyone works, parties and performs together. Even the new entrants are offshoots of established camps, whether it is Ranbir Kapoor or Imran Khan. Perhaps Bollywood needs to take a leaf out of the books of southern superstars, Rajnikant and Kamal Haasan, who tend to let their work speak for themselves. At least it makes for better cinema. ■